the Sikh community to rethink its position over conversions. That hardening of stance notwithstanding, it would be difficult to spot, in what's unfolding in Punjab, signs of force or inducement—unless you define those in spiritual terms. The devotion of the flocks is, to the naked eye, entirely volitional; consent as freely given as the benedictions flowing from the altar.

But things are coming to a head. On August 29, a group of Nihangs disrupted a programme at a Pentecostal church in Daduana village, Amritsar, alleging "forced conversions". Two days later, four masked intruders made a pre-dawn swoop on a Catholic church in Thakkarpura village, Tarn Taran, held the guard at gunpoint, vandalised statues and burnt the priest's car. The Catholic establishment initially staged a protest, but later sought to downplay it as a "local burglary". And on October 8, a new arrival on the scene—the young, Dubai-returned Amritpal Singh, reborn as a turbaned 'Second Bhindranwale', complete with fiery oratory—cavilled against conversions during his quasi-coronation at Rode village on October 8 thus: "Those who indulge in sacrilege will not be handed over to police or sent to courts. *Ohda sodha laguga* (we will punish them)."

These pastors borrow freely from Punjab's cultural markers—turban, langar (rechristened Jesus da langar), the tappa song, the gidda dance

HANDLING THE BACKLASH

Christian activists took out mass protests on October 18 but, overall, there is a pall of hushed fear. Many of the pastors the INDIA TODAY team met were reluctant to be photographed. Despite repeated attempts, Narula refused to meet too, though he does use his sermons to respond to charges made by Sikh groups. All the tumult has goaded the pastors into coming together. Last November, Deol floated the Pentecostal Church Parbandhak Committee (PCPC) to bring together independent pastors and introduce a measure of self-regulation. Over 1,000 pastors are now registered under PCPC, Deol says, though the going is tough. A need is being felt for political representation, and big names like Narula are using their network of "loyal" pastors—who see in him a spiritual father—in that quest. There are Christian members in local bodies and panchayats, yet Punjab has no Christian MLA or MP.

Punjab, of course, is no stranger to Christianity. Indeed, its arrival in the mid-19th century unwittingly became a formative event in its religious and social life. The Arya Samaj was set up in 1875 explicitly as a counter to perceived threats to Hinduism—Dayanand Saraswati being stung by the ill-tempered denunciations of Hinduism by European missionaries. But his neo-Vedic bulwark, which became a mainstay of Hinduism in Punjab, had itself absorbed

